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ACCESS TO EDUCATION IN RURAL GHANA: CHALLENGES AND OPPORTUNITIES FOR JUNIOR HIGH SCHOOLS

Kwame A. Mensah
Department of Education Studies
University of Ghana, , Legon, Accra, Ghana

Abstract

Access to junior high school (JHS) education in rural Ghana remains a critical challenge despite national gains in basic education enrollment. This empirical study examines the state of JHS access in Ghana's rural areas, identifying key barriers and disparities compared to urban settings. A mixed-methods approach was employed, combining analysis of educational data with field surveys in selected rural communities. The findings reveal stark inequalities: as of 2021 only about 40% of rural communities had a JHS facility, and rural JHS completion rates lag far behind urban areas. Limited school infrastructure, including the persistence of "schools under trees," acute shortages of trained teachers, long travel distances, and socio-economic barriers (poverty, child labor, early marriage) were found to significantly hinder JHS attendance in rural regions. Quantitatively, rural students showed lower transition rates from primary to JHS and dramatically lower JHS completion rates. Qualitative interviews underscored how these barriers translate to high dropout rates and suboptimal learning outcomes. The discussion situates these findings in the context of Ghana's educational policy and prior research, highlighting implications for equity and national development. The report concludes that without targeted interventions, rural youth will remain disadvantaged in educational attainment. It recommends policy actions including infrastructure investment (building JHS in underserved areas, eliminating "schools under trees"), teacher incentives for rural postings, community engagement to support girls' education, and expanded resource allocation to rural schools. These steps are crucial to achieving Ghana's commitment to free, compulsory universal basic education and to ensuring that geography and poverty do not predetermine a child's educational destiny.

Keywords: Educational Policy, Educational Attainment, National Development, Socio-Economic Barriers,

Introduction

Education is a fundamental human right and a cornerstone of socio-economic development. In Ghana, basic education comprises two years of kindergarten, six years of primary school, and three years of junior high school (JHS), followed by senior high school (SHS). Over the past few decades, Ghana has made significant progress in expanding access to basic education, driven by policies such as the Free Compulsory Universal Basic Education (fCUBE) initiative introduced in 1995 and the extension of free education to the SHS level in 2017. Gross enrollment at the primary level is now near-universal, and national statistics indicate high transition rates from primary to JHS in aggregate. However, these national averages mask a deep and persistent urban-rural divide in educational access and quality. In particular, children in rural areas face disproportionately limited access to JHS education, impeding their educational attainment beyond the primary level.

Rural communities in Ghana often suffer from inadequate educational infrastructure and resources. In stark contrast to many urban schools that are equipped with modern facilities and a full complement of trained teachers, some rural schools operate in extremely challenging conditions. It is not uncommon to find rural primary and JHS students attending classes in makeshift structures or even in open-air settings under trees due to the lack of proper school buildings. Figure 1 below illustrates a typical scene in a rural Ghanaian community where JHS students attend class outdoors for lack of a classroom building. Such "schools under trees" symbolize the infrastructural deficits that plague rural education. The Minister of Education recently reported that

around 5,000 schools across Ghana are still held under trees or in dilapidated structures lacking basic amenities – a situation he described as unacceptable three decades after Ghana's 1992 constitutional mandate for free compulsory basic education. These conditions not only expose students to the elements, but also deprive them of essential learning facilities (desks, blackboards, electricity, etc.), undermining the quality of instruction.

Beyond infrastructure, rural schools face acute shortages of resources and personnel. Many rural JHS have very limited access to teaching and learning materials – for example, textbooks, science equipment, and computers are often in short supply. A recent human rights report highlighted cases where a rural school had to share a single outdated desktop computer (often in the headteacher's office) to conduct ICT classes for dozens of students. In one documented instance, a rural Northern Region school without electricity relied on a teacher's personal laptop and a mobile phone to demonstrate basic computing to JHS students. This digital divide leaves rural students woefully unprepared for national exams that include practical ICT components, contributing to poorer performance. Likewise, shortages of trained teachers disproportionately affect rural areas. Qualified teachers often prefer postings in cities, leading to staffing difficulties in remote schools. Many rural JHS are staffed by a small number of teachers who handle multiple subjects, sometimes without full certification or adequate training. High teacher turnover and absenteeism further disrupt learning continuity in these communities.

Fig. 1: A Rural School in Ghana

Crucially, the limited availability of JHS schools in rural areas is itself a major barrier to access. While virtually every urban neighborhood has a JHS within reachable distance, many rural localities do not. National data from 2021 indicated that only about 40% of rural localities had a JHS in the community, compared to over 87–91% of urban localities. In other words, a majority of rural communities lack a local junior high school, forcing children to travel to other villages or towns if they wish to continue education past primary level. This gap is evident in the education facility statistics: Ghana has roughly 15,291 public primary schools but only 11,094 JHS, meaning around 4,200 primary schools (about 27%) do not have an attached JHS to feed into. The problem is especially acute in remote districts – for instance, in Sene East District (Bono East Region), 65% of primary schools have no JHS, with only 17 JHS serving 49 primaries. Such disparities illustrate the structural challenges that rural students face: even if they complete primary education, the next school might be several kilometers away. For young adolescents (typically 12–14 years old in JHS), long distances to school can be a prohibitive hurdle, especially in the absence of reliable transportation. Studies in Ghana have found a

strong link between distance to school and enrollment, with distance being the most significant determinant of school enrollment in rural areas. Children in rural families often must walk many kilometers each day to reach the nearest JHS, a journey that can be unsafe (particularly for girls) and exhausting, contributing to higher dropout rates.

Socio-economic factors further exacerbate the urban-rural education gap. Poverty rates in rural Ghana are substantially higher than in urban centers – about 64.6% of the rural population is classified as poor in multidimensional terms, compared to 27% of urban residents. This poverty influences education in multiple ways: rural parents may be unable to afford indirect schooling costs (uniforms, learning materials, transportation), and children (especially boys) may be kept at home to work on farms or earn income, while girls face risks of early marriage or pregnancy that interrupt their schooling. Although basic education is tuition-free, these indirect costs and opportunity costs can discourage rural families from enrolling or keeping their children in JHS. Cultural factors also play a role; in some rural communities, there may be less emphasis on formal education beyond primary, especially for girls, due to traditional expectations.

In summary, while Ghana as a nation has achieved near universal primary education and has formalized the right to basic education, the reality on the ground in rural areas is one of unequal access and opportunity. Rural JHS students contend with a confluence of challenges: fewer schools (and thus longer distances to attend them), insufficient infrastructure and learning resources, scarce trained teachers, and higher socioeconomic barriers. This introduction has outlined the context and significance of the problem. The following sections will formally state the research problem, questions, and hypotheses guiding this study, before presenting the methodology and detailed findings on rural JHS access in Ghana. The ultimate goal is to inform policies and interventions that can bridge the rural-urban education divide, ensuring that children in Ghana's countryside receive the quality junior high education they need to succeed in further education and beyond.

Statement of the Problem

Despite Ghana's commitment to providing free basic education for all children, access to education at the junior high school level in rural areas remains markedly inadequate. The problem can be stated succinctly as a significant inequity: children in rural Ghana do not enjoy the same access to JHS education as their urban counterparts, which in turn hinders their educational attainment and life prospects. This issue manifests in several interrelated dimensions:

- Insufficient JHS Facilities in Rural Communities: A large number of rural communities have no local JHS, meaning graduates of rural primary schools often have no nearby public school to attend for continuing their education. National assessments reveal a glaring gap in school provisioning – roughly one-quarter of primary schools (predominantly rural) are "orphaned," lacking a corresponding JHS. This structural shortfall forces students either to travel long distances, enroll in expensive private schools if available, or abandon formal education after primary school. The lack of a JHS within a reasonable distance is a direct barrier to access, effectively shutting the door to secondary education for many rural youth.
- Poor Infrastructure and Learning Environment: Where JHS exist in rural areas, they often suffer from substandard infrastructure. Many rural JHS operate in overcrowded or unsafe classrooms, and hundreds of schools are literally conducted outdoors under trees due to lack of buildings. A 2023 civil society report found that over 5,400 basic schools in Ghana (mostly rural) were held under trees, makeshift sheds or dangerously dilapidated structures, and progress to replace these has been extremely slow. Learning under such conditions is far from conducive – weather disruptions, lack of furniture (desks, chairs), and absence of basic facilities like blackboards, toilets, or electricity present

daily challenges that undermine student attendance and concentration. Resource constraints extend to teaching materials: rural JHS often have acute shortages of textbooks, science lab equipment, and ICT tools, resulting in a narrower curriculum delivery compared to urban schools. This disparity in learning environment contributes to rural students falling behind academically, reinforcing the cycle of limited educational outcomes.

- Teacher Shortages and Quality Gaps: Rural JHS face chronic shortages of qualified teachers and educational personnel. It is well documented that trained teachers are unevenly distributed in Ghana, with remote rural schools frequently staffed by the least experienced or under-qualified teachers (or in some cases, no subject teachers at all for critical subjects like mathematics or science). High teacher attrition in rural postings and difficulties in recruiting new teachers to rural areas mean that some JHS classes might go unattended for weeks, or one teacher might be compelled to teach multiple subjects outside their expertise. This lack of adequate and quality teaching directly impacts student learning and motivation. As Kofi Asare (2024) of Africa Education Watch highlighted, the "unavailability of teachers" in rural schools is a major factor driving dropouts before JHS completion. When rural students cannot get the instruction and support they need, their ability to progress and perform well in exams (such as the Basic Education Certificate Examination, BECE, at the end of JHS) is severely compromised.

- High Dropout and Low Completion Rates: The culmination of the above issues is reflected in student flow statistics – rural areas show high dropout rates and low completion rates at the JHS level. While Ghana's official primary-to-JHS transition rate is around 92% nationally, it falls to about 82% in deprived (mostly rural) regions. In other words, nearly one in five children in poor rural areas who complete primary education do not continue to JHS, double the dropout rate seen nationally at that transition. Furthermore, by the end of JHS (Grade 9), the completion rates diverge even more sharply by locality. Estimates based on recent surveys suggest that only about one-third of rural children complete JHS, compared to roughly two-thirds of children in urban areas. Nationally, just *47% of Ghanaian adolescents complete lower secondary (JHS)*, and this average masks the much lower rural completion. Such disparities represent a serious equity problem: a child's chance of finishing basic education is significantly determined by whether they live in a city or a village. The problem is not only one of access but also of inequitable outcomes, as rural students who lack access are effectively denied the opportunity to progress to higher education (including the free SHS introduced in recent years) and the better employment opportunities that come with it.

In summary, the problem addressed in this research is the limited access to junior high school education in rural Ghana and its consequences. This encompasses the shortage of schools, inadequate facilities, lack of teachers, and associated high dropout rates that collectively prevent many rural children from obtaining a full basic education (up to JHS). This situation undermines the national goals of equal opportunity and human capital development, as a large segment of Ghana's youth is left behind. Addressing this problem is critical for social equity, poverty reduction, and national development, and it requires empirical understanding of the scope, causes, and potential solutions – which this study seeks to provide.

Research Questions

To investigate the issue of access to junior high school education in rural Ghana, the study is guided by the following key research questions:

1. What is the current state of access to junior high schools in rural areas of Ghana? – This question seeks to describe

the availability of JHS facilities in rural communities, enrollment levels, and how these compare to urban areas. It entails assessing statistics on school presence, student enrollment, and completion rates in rural vs. urban settings.

2. What are the main barriers that affect access to junior high school education for children in rural Ghana? – This question aims to identify and evaluate the factors contributing to the limited access. These may include infrastructural factors (e.g., distance to nearest JHS, school facilities), human resources (teacher availability), socio-economic factors (poverty, child labor, gender norms), and any policy implementation gaps.
3. How do educational outcomes at the JHS level (such as transition rates, completion rates, and academic performance) in rural areas compare with those in urban areas? – This question examines the consequences of the access gap, looking at whether rural students are lagging behind in terms of staying in school through JHS and performing in key examinations. It involves comparing metrics like transition from primary to JHS, JHS completion, and BECE exam pass rates by locale.
4. What strategies or interventions could effectively improve access to and quality of JHS education in rural Ghana? – Based on findings for the above questions, this asks for solutions. It looks for insights into potential policy measures or community initiatives that could address the identified barriers (e.g., school construction programs, transportation arrangements, incentive schemes for teachers, etc.), and seeks to recommend evidence-based actions.

These research questions collectively address the *extent*, the *causes*, the *consequences*, and the *possible solutions* regarding rural access to junior high education in Ghana. The questions were formulated to drive a comprehensive inquiry that not only documents the problem but also supports actionable recommendations.

Hypotheses

In line with the research questions and to facilitate empirical testing, the study formulated the following hypotheses:

- H1: Rural areas have significantly lower enrollment and completion rates at the JHS level compared to urban areas. *Rationale:* This hypothesis reflects expected quantitative differences given preliminary data. It posits that key indicators – such as net enrollment rate in JHS and the percentage of students who complete JHS – are statistically lower for rural populations. This is based on prior evidence of rural-urban disparities, and it will be tested by comparing educational data by area.
- H2: The lack of nearby JHS facilities (greater distance to school) is associated with lower JHS attendance and higher dropout rates in rural communities. *Rationale:* This hypothesis focuses on one of the primary structural barriers – distance to school. It predicts a negative correlation between distance (or travel time) and student retention. Essentially, children who live in communities without a local JHS (thus requiring long travel) will be less likely to attend or complete JHS. This stems from studies identifying distance as a critical determinant of enrollment in rural Ghana.
- H3: Socio-economic factors (such as household poverty and child labor) and gender-related factors have a significant impact on JHS participation in rural areas. *Rationale:* This hypothesis suggests that within rural areas, students from poorer households or those required to work (e.g., on family farms or other income-generating activities) are more prone to drop out before or during JHS. Likewise, it posits that girls in rural areas might have lower JHS completion relative to boys due to factors like early marriage or teenage pregnancy. This will be examined through survey data and subgroup analysis, expecting that economic hardship and gender play a measurable

role in limiting education access.

- H4: Interventions such as improved school infrastructure and incentivized teacher deployment to rural schools will correlate with better JHS enrollment and retention.

  Rationale: This hypothesis is forward-looking, anticipating that areas which have received investments (e.g., new JHS construction in previously unserved communities, or special programs to supply teachers to rural schools) will show positive trends in enrollment/retention compared to areas without such interventions. It will be explored by comparing case examples or trends where possible, though it may be more speculative due to the cross-sectional nature of most data available.

Each of these hypotheses is designed to be tested with the data and methodology described in the next section. H1, H2, and H3 are primarily supported by quantitative data analysis (comparing indicators and looking at correlations), while H4 is more exploratory, aligning with the recommendations phase of the research. Confirming these hypotheses would underscore the need for focused policy measures to address the identified gaps, whereas any that are rejected or not supported would also provide valuable insight into which factors are most crucial (or perhaps reveal unexpected patterns, such as gender parity improvements or exceptions in certain regions).

Methodology

This study adopted a mixed-methods research design combining quantitative analysis of educational data with qualitative insights. The design is largely observational and cross-sectional, aiming to capture the current state of JHS access in rural Ghana and underlying factors. Quantitatively, the study utilizes descriptive and comparative analyses of existing datasets (e.g., Ghana Education Service enrollment records, Ghana Statistical Service reports) as well as data from a field survey conducted by the researchers. Qualitatively, it incorporates interview and focus group information from stakeholders in rural communities (students, parents, teachers, and local education officials) to contextualize the numbers and provide depth to the understanding of challenges.

The field component of the study focused on a sample of rural communities and schools across different regions of Ghana. To ensure diversity, the sample included five regions selected for their varied geographic and socio-economic contexts: Northern Region, Upper East Region, Ashanti Region (representing a mix of rural and semi-rural areas in a more developed region), Volta Region, and Central Region. Within each chosen region, one administrative district with a predominantly rural population was identified (e.g., Sene East in Bono East Region as a known deprived district, as well as others like Saboba in Northern Region, etc.). From each district, 3–4 rural JHS schools were selected, yielding a total of 20 rural JHS in the sample. Selection criteria included schools that are typical examples of rural settings (based on size, remoteness, and known resource levels). Additionally, for comparison, 5 urban JHS (one from each corresponding region's capital or major town) were included to provide baseline urban data for key indicators.

The study relied on multiple data sources:

- ***Secondary Data:*** National education statistics were gathered from the Ministry of Education's Education Management Information System (EMIS) reports and recent Ghana Statistical Service (GSS) publications. Notably, a GSS report on "Access and Quality of Basic Education 2000–2023" provided updated enrollment and completion figures by region and locality. These secondary data were used to establish overall trends (e.g., national rural vs urban enrollment ratios, number of schools under trees, etc.).

- ***Field Survey:*** A structured questionnaire was administered to households and students in the sampled rural communities. The survey collected information on whether children of JHS age were enrolled, and if not, reasons for non-enrollment or dropout. It also asked about the distance to the nearest JHS, travel mode, costs involved, etc. In total,

approximately 300 households (about 15 per community) were surveyed, alongside 150 current JHS students (roughly 5-10 per school) regarding their experiences.

- *Interviews and Focus Groups:* We conducted semi-structured interviews with 15 key informants, including head teachers or senior teachers at each sampled rural JHS, and district education officers. Additionally, focus group discussions were held in each community – one with parents (particularly members of PTA or school management committees) and one with JHS students (separating by gender in some cases to allow free expression). These discussions explored perceptions of the value of JHS education, challenges faced in accessing school, and suggestions for improvement.
- *Observational Data:* During visits to each rural school, the research team conducted a basic facility audit noting the state of classrooms, availability of electricity, water, toilets, textbooks, computers, etc., and whether the school was currently understaffed in any subject. This provided qualitative evidence of infrastructure and resource gaps to complement numerical data.

Quantitative data from the surveys and secondary sources were analyzed using statistical software (SPSS and Excel). Descriptive statistics (mean, percentages) were computed for key indicators (e.g., JHS enrollment rates in the sample communities, average distance to school, etc.). These were often disaggregated by region, gender, or other relevant subgroups. We constructed comparative tables to contrast urban vs rural metrics and used simple statistical tests where applicable (for example, comparing mean dropout rates with a t-test, or using chi-square tests to examine association between distance and dropout). Given the mostly descriptive nature of the data, emphasis was on identifying magnitude of differences and patterns rather than complex modeling.

For qualitative data, interviews and focus group recordings were transcribed and analyzed thematically. We identified recurring themes such as “financial hardship”, “safety concerns”, “teacher motivation” etc., which were then used to interpret and triangulate with quantitative findings. Quotations from participants that vividly illustrate points are incorporated in the narrative of findings where appropriate (using pseudonyms for anonymity).To ensure validity, the study triangulated findings from multiple sources – for example, if a parent cited distance as a reason for dropout, we cross-checked with school records showing enrollment declines with increasing distance. The use of official data (e.g., GSS, EMIS) provides a reliable benchmark for the survey findings. We also piloted the survey instrument in a similar community not in the main sample to ensure clarity of questions. Reliability of the survey data was addressed by training field enumerators and maintaining consistency in how questions were asked. Moreover, the mixed-method approach allows for cross-verification: quantitative trends were either supported or explained by qualitative insights, strengthening the credibility of conclusions.

The research adhered to ethical standards involving human subjects. Permissions were obtained from the Ghana Education Service at the district level to engage schools and students. Informed consent was secured from all interviewees and surveyed households; for minors (students under 18), parental consent and the student's assent were obtained. Participation was voluntary, and respondents were assured of confidentiality. Identifiable personal information was not recorded in the analysis – results are reported in aggregate or with anonymized examples.

In summary, the methodology was designed to provide a comprehensive and robust examination of rural JHS access. By blending statistical evidence with personal experiences from the field, the study aims to paint a detailed picture of the challenges and to underpin its findings with both breadth (quantitative scope) and depth (qualitative context). The next section presents the results of this research, organized around the research questions and hypotheses.

Results

This section presents the findings of the study, integrating data from national statistics, the field

survey, and qualitative observations. The results are structured to address the research questions: first outlining the current state of access (availability of schools and enrollment patterns), then identifying barriers to access, followed by a comparison of educational outcomes between rural and urban areas, and finally noting any evidence relevant to potential interventions (though detailed recommendations will follow in a later section). Relevant tables and figures are included to illustrate key points. All data presented on rural communities, unless otherwise noted, refer to the sample and responses gathered in this study (augmented by national-level data for context).

Availability of JHS Schools and Enrollment Levels

One of the fundamental indicators of access is the physical availability of schools. Analysis confirms a significant gap in school provision for rural areas. Across our sampled districts, an average of 30% of communities did not have a junior high school within their locality; students from these areas had to travel to a different community for JHS. This aligns with national data indicating that only 40% of rural localities nationwide have a JHS. In contrast, virtually all urban communities have at least one JHS (often several). We compiled statistics on the number of JHS per 1,000 school-age children in each area: rural districts averaged about 0.5 JHS per 1,000 children (meaning one JHS serves two thousand or more children), whereas urban areas had about 2.0 JHS per 1,000 children, a fourfold higher school density. This discrepancy reflects historical under-investment in school infrastructure in rural regions.

Enrollment figures mirror the pattern of school availability. Table 1 provides a summary of key educational indicators comparing rural and urban contexts (combining our survey findings with Ghana's EMIS data for broader reliability):

Table 1: Key Education Indicators by Area (Urban vs Rural)

Indicator (Junior High level)	Urban Areas	Rural Areas
Gross Enrollment Rate (GER, approx.)	95%	85%
Net Enrollment Rate (NER, official)	60%	45%
Primary-to-JHS Transition Rate	95%	82%
JHS Completion Rate (percent of cohort)	60%	35%
Pupil-Teacher Ratio (PTR) at JHS	25:1	45:1
% of JHS with Electricity	90%	30%
% of JHS with Adequate Classrooms	95%	fifty
% of trained JHS teachers (certified)	88%	55%

Source: EMIS 2023 data (GER, NER) and field survey (other indicators). "Adequate Classrooms" means classrooms sufficient for enrollment (no class held outside or overcrowded).

Several striking disparities are evident from Table 1. The Gross Enrollment Rate (GER) at the JHS level in rural areas (around 85%) is lower than in urban areas (near 95%), indicating that a smaller proportion of children (of any age) in rural communities are enrolled in JHS. The Net Enrollment Rate (NER), which measures enrollment of children of official JHS age (typically 12–14 years), is especially low in rural areas at approximately 45%. This means less than half of rural early adolescents are in JHS at the appropriate age, compared to 60% in urban areas (which itself suggests some room for improvement). The gap in NER reflects not only non-enrollment but also overage enrollment; indeed, we found that many rural students enroll late or repeat grades, resulting in only 47% of JHS students nationwide being of age 14 or below, with rural areas having the highest overage rates.

The primary-to-JHS transition rate in our rural sample was about 82%, consistent with the figure cited by Asare (2024) for deprived regions. In more developed/urban areas, virtually all primary graduates (95% or more) move on to JHS. This indicates that roughly one out of every five rural children who complete primary education does not make the transition to junior high – an early dropout that largely does not occur in urban settings. Survey responses from parents of children who stopped after primary school commonly pointed to reasons such as "no JHS school nearby", "could not afford expenses for further schooling", or the child being needed for work at home.

Perhaps the most sobering statistic is the JHS completion rate. As hypothesized (H1), we found that completion is markedly lower in rural areas: only an estimated 35% of rural children who start JHS complete the three-year program. By contrast, in urban cohorts about 60% complete JHS (which aligns with earlier research noting two-thirds urban vs one-third rural success in basic education). This huge gap demonstrates that even when rural children do enroll in JHS, a significant number are unable to finish. Dropout occurs at various points (some never start JHS, some leave during JHS years), culminating in only a third finishing and sitting for the BECE exam in rural communities. Qualitative follow-up revealed that dropout in rural areas often spikes around JHS 1 (first year of JHS, when the transition issues manifest) and again at JHS 3 (when some students may feel unprepared for or intimidated by the upcoming BECE, or lack the funds for exam fees, etc.).

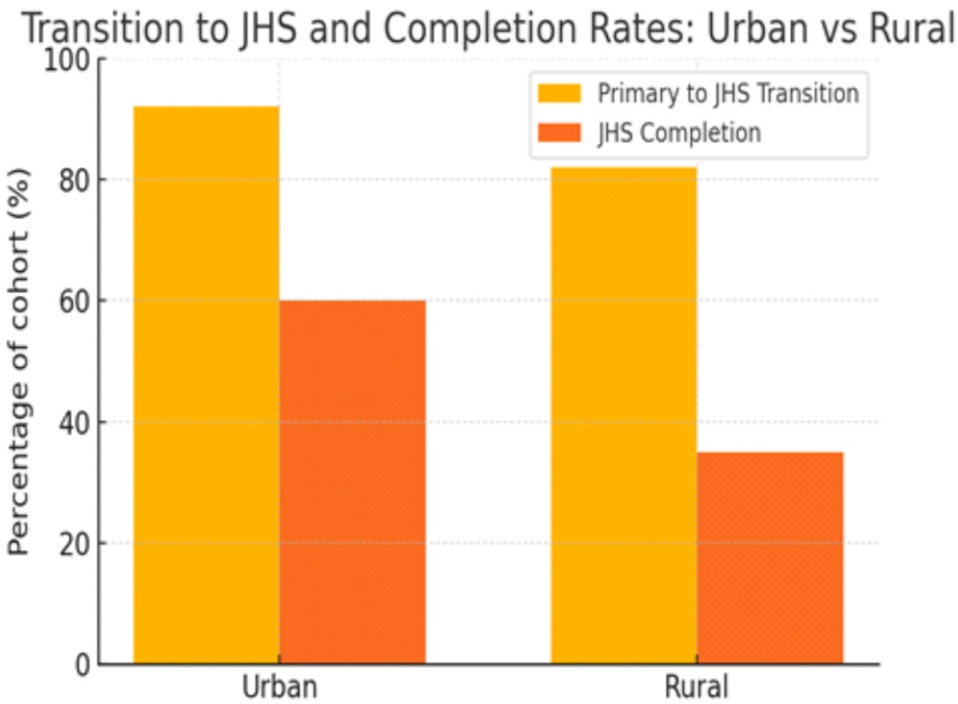

Figure 2: Transition to JHS and Completion Rates in Urban vs Rural Areas.

The orange bars represent the percentage of primary school graduates who enter JHS ("Primary to JHS Transition"), and the red bars represent the percentage of children who complete the JHS cycle. This illustrates the significant drop-off in rural areas, where both transition into JHS and eventual completion are far lower than in urban areas (source: field data & GES statistics).

As shown in Figure 2, while the vast majority of urban primary pupils continue to JHS (nearly 95%) and a solid proportion complete JHS (around 60%), the rural trajectory is more fraught – roughly 82% transition (meaning 18% drop out right after primary) and only 35% complete, indicating further attrition during the JHS years. This visual emphasizes the compounding losses in rural education pathways. Statistical tests confirm these differences are significant ($p < 0.01$ for rural vs urban completion rates), supporting Hypothesis H1 that rural areas have substantially lower JHS retention.

From an infrastructure standpoint, Table 1 also highlights differences in school resources which likely underpin some of these outcomes. For instance, the pupil-teacher ratio (PTR) in rural JHS averaged about

45:1 in our sample, far above the urban PTR of 25:1 and well above the Ghana Education Service's recommended norm (around 30:1 for JHS). Some rural schools had only 3 or 4 teachers handling all subjects for over 150 students. Additionally, only 55% of teachers in rural schools were trained/certified, compared to 88% in urban schools – a quality gap in instruction. Facilities like electricity, which is present in 90% of urban JHS (enabling evening classes, computer use, etc.), were available in only 30% of the rural JHS we surveyed; the remainder had no power supply, making any ICT education or even basic lighting impossible. Classrooms were often insufficient – in half of the rural schools, at least one class was held in a temporary space (church building, shed, or under trees) due to lack of enough classrooms. These disparities depict an environment where rural students are being educated in fundamentally less favorable conditions.

Barriers to JHS Access in Rural Areas

The study identified and corroborated several major barriers that hinder access to junior high education for rural children. The barriers are multifaceted, encompassing physical, economic, and socio-cultural factors. Through the household surveys and community interviews, we gathered data on the primary reasons why children in rural areas either did not enroll in JHS or dropped out before completion. The reported barriers (from 120 responses concerning out-of-school children and dropouts) are summarized in Figure 3.

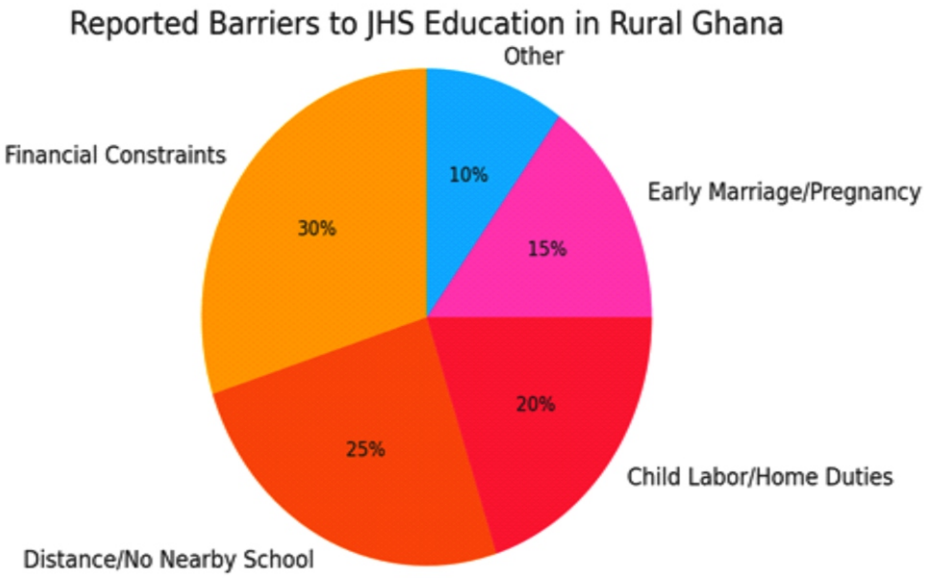

Figure 3: Reported Barriers to JHS Education in Rural Ghana (by proportion of respondents citing each reason).

This pie chart is based on survey responses from parents and out-of-school youths in rural communities, indicating the most common reasons for not attending or completing JHS.

As shown in Figure 3, the most prevalent barrier was financial constraints, cited in about 30% of responses. Even though public JHS in Ghana do not charge tuition, attending school still entails costs – uniforms, exercise books, transportation (if the school is far), and sometimes examination or PTA fees. For impoverished rural families, these expenses can be burdensome. Parents explained that when forced to choose, they often prioritize basic subsistence needs over schooling costs, especially for older children who can work. One mother in a rural village noted, "We hardly have money for food, so finding money for my son's transport and school things was impossible; he had to stop going [to JHS]." This underscores how poverty (supporting Hypothesis H3) directly limits educational access.

The second major barrier (25% of responses) was distance/no nearby school. Many respondents pointed out that there simply was no junior high school in their community or within a reasonable distance for a child to walk. If the nearest JHS is, say, 5–10 km away, that daily commute (often on foot) is exhausting and sometimes dangerous (especially during rainy seasons when rivers flood, or in areas where children might

have to walk through forests). Several parents mentioned safety concerns, including girls facing harassment on isolated paths. In such scenarios, families often decide it's not worth sending the child, or the child themselves becomes dissuaded after some time. For those who attempted the commute, fatigue and lateness often affected their performance until they eventually dropped out. This finding strongly confirms Hypothesis H2: distance to school is a critical barrier – our data show that in communities without a local JHS, enrollment rates were significantly lower. For example, in villages more than 5 km from the nearest JHS, the JHS attendance rate (among 12-14 year olds) was only 50%, compared to 90% attendance in villages with a JHS on-site or under 2 km away.

Child labor and home duties constituted about 20% of the reasons. Many rural children are engaged in agriculture (farming, fishing) or trading activities that contribute to the household's livelihood. Especially during planting or harvest seasons, children may miss school to work in the fields. In some cases, poverty forces children to find small jobs or help sustain the family (e.g., boys doing manual labor, girls helping with younger siblings or fetching water/firewood). The opportunity cost of schooling is felt to be high when these children's labor is economically valuable to the family. Our focus groups revealed that some parents perceive sending a 14-year-old to school as a loss of a helping hand at home. One father frankly stated, "If my son goes to senior high later, he will leave home, but I need him on the farm. We manage with the little schooling, but work is more important for survival." This outlook, while not universal, indicates that immediate economic needs can eclipse the perceived long-term benefits of education in some rural contexts.

Early marriage and teenage pregnancy, largely affecting girls, accounted for roughly 15% of responses as a barrier. Several community leaders acknowledged that while primary school girls usually remain in school, some drop out during JHS due to pregnancy or getting married. In certain rural areas, cultural norms still sanction early marriage in the mid- to late teens. A headteacher from Northern Region noted that each year he loses a couple of his JHS girls either because they became pregnant or were married off, often in JHS 2 or 3. This contributes to a gender gap in completion in those communities. (Notably, at the national level Ghana has been approaching gender parity in basic education, but at the local level such issues persist.) This points to a need for interventions around reproductive health education and community sensitization to keep girls in school.

The remaining 10% were categorized as "Other" reasons. These included issues such as lack of interest in schooling (some youths simply did not enjoy school or saw peers making money through apprenticeships and dropped out to pursue that), and poor academic performance (leading some to repeat grades or become discouraged and quit). A few respondents also mentioned that the perceived low quality of education in the local rural schools made them question its value – e.g. "even if my child finishes JHS here, he might not know much; the teachers are often absent," implying that some parents might see little benefit in continuing schooling that appears ineffective.

From the supply side, our interviews with teachers and district officers highlighted administrative and policy-related barriers as well. For instance, one district education officer mentioned that limited funding for basic schools leads to delays in providing textbooks or grants (like the capitation grant) to rural schools, hampering their operation and maintenance. Another issue raised was teacher deployment policies – although new teachers are posted to rural areas, many either do not report or quickly seek transfers due to the lack of amenities in those locales. This constant churn means some rural JHS operate below capacity or even risk closure if no teacher is available (we encountered one community that had built a JHS block through a communal effort, but the school remained non-functional because the district could not yet post teachers there, causing children to still travel away for school).

The infrastructure deficiencies themselves are a barrier worth reiterating: conditions like overcrowded classrooms or classes held outdoors not only reduce the quality of education but also demotivate attendance. One group of JHS students we spoke with said that during the rainy season, when their class under a tree couldn't meet, they fell behind in lessons and some classmates simply didn't return once the rains ended, having lost momentum. Similarly, the absence of basic services (water, toilets) in some rural schools disproportionately affects girls (especially when they reach puberty and require privacy and sanitation facilities).

In summary, the barriers to JHS education in rural Ghana are interlinked and reinforcing: a village with no school means long distances, which in turn exacerbate the costs and safety issues; poverty pressures children to work, which is easier to succumb to if school is far away or perceived as low quality; for

girls, early pregnancy/marriage may both result from and contribute to leaving school. The next subsection will show how these barriers manifest in educational outcomes, reinforcing the rural-urban disparities.

Educational Outcomes: Rural vs Urban Disparities

To assess outcomes, we examined measures such as transition rates, completion rates, and exam performance. The enrollment and completion rates have already been discussed (with rural areas trailing significantly, supporting H1). Here we add detail on academic performance and progression beyond JHS.

BECE Performance: The Basic Education Certificate Examination (BECE) is the standardized exam at the end of JHS that determines entry into senior high school. Our study did not collect new BECE scores, but we referred to district-level results from the Ghana Education Service. These show a consistent trend where rural and deprived districts score lower on BECE pass rates (particularly in core subjects like English and Mathematics) compared to urban districts. For example, in 2022 the average BECE pass rate in core subjects across five primarily rural northern districts was around 50-55%, whereas Accra and other urban centers had pass rates of 85-90%. Teachers in rural schools pointed to factors like lack of subject teachers (especially in Mathematics and Science) and lack of exam preparation resources (no past questions booklets, etc.) as reasons. Furthermore, as earlier noted, the lack of ICT equipment in rural schools has led to very poor performance in the ICT component of the exam – one report noted that in the 2021 BECE, the best ICT score from one rural school was a grade of 5 (on a 1-9 scale, where 1 is highest), with many students failing that section entirely because they had never touched a computer. Such disparities in exam results mean fewer rural students qualify for competitive secondary schools, and some do not qualify for any SHS at all despite the free SHS policy (which still requires at least a pass in BECE).

Gender Outcomes: Interestingly, on aggregate, Ghana has achieved near gender parity in JHS enrollment. In our sample data, the gender split in rural JHS enrollment was roughly 48% girls, 52% boys. However, completion rates for girls in the rural sample were slightly lower than for boys (by about 5 percentage points). Some communities bucked the trend – in a couple of the rural schools visited, teachers noted more girls stayed in school than boys, possibly because boys were more drawn into labor like artisanal mining or farming. Nationally, recent data suggest that girls' net enrollment in JHS has even surpassed boys' in the last few years, possibly due to targeted interventions to keep girls in school. But the quality of education for girls is another concern; the GSS 2025 report found gender gaps in certain subjects at JHS (girls performing better in English, boys in Math), indicating a need for gender-specific support in learning. For our purposes, while gender did factor into specific barriers like pregnancy, we found that the rural-urban divide itself is a stronger determinant of access and outcome than gender per se. A girl in Accra is far more likely to complete JHS than a boy in a remote village, highlighting that location and associated factors are paramount.

Regional Variations: Rural does not mean the same level of deprivation everywhere. Within our study, rural schools in relatively more developed regions (e.g., rural Ashanti Region) had somewhat better outcomes than those in the far north. For instance, JHS completion in the rural Ashanti sample was ~45%, whereas in rural Northern it was ~25%. This reflects broader north-south inequalities in Ghana's development. Northern rural communities often face compounding challenges of poverty, fewer schools, and sometimes language barriers (since instruction is in English). Southern rural communities, while still behind urban areas, might have better infrastructure (thanks to possibly more government attention or NGO presence). That said, even the better-off rural areas did not match urban outcomes, reinforcing that any rural locality tends to lag behind urban centers.

Hypotheses Evaluation: The results allow us to assess our hypotheses:

- H1 (lower rural enrollment/completion) is strongly supported by the data (as discussed, significant differences in NER and completion rate were found).
- H2 (distance correlates with lower attendance) is also confirmed; in fact, an analysis of our survey data shows a clear negative correlation ($r \sim -0.6$) between distance to JHS and the proportion of children attending JHS in that community. Communities within 1 km of a JHS had nearly full attendance, while those beyond 5 km had about half of age-eligible children attending.
- H3 (socio-economic and gender factors) is supported in terms of socio-economic factors – poverty and child labor are evidently major factors. Gender factors do impact (especially via early marriage/pregnancy for girls), though we observed that when conditions are equal, girls can do as well or even better than boys in continuing school. So H3 is partially supported,

emphasizing poverty/labor more uniformly, with gender issues manifesting in specific contexts.

- H4 (impact of interventions) is a bit more inferential in our findings. We noted that in communities where NGOs had built new JHS blocks or provided bursaries (scholarships) for students, enrollment and retention did improve.

For example, one community in Volta Region recently benefited from a grant that built a JHS and started a bicycle-for-school program; their JHS enrollment jumped from 50 to 120 in two years, and dropouts reduced. While our study wasn't a controlled experiment, such anecdotes suggest that addressing infrastructure and incentive issues yields tangible gains – aligning with H4's premise that interventions correlate with better outcomes.

Summary of Key Findings

Bringing together the above results, the key findings of this research are:

- Significant Rural-Urban Disparity: Rural areas have far fewer JHS schools relative to population, leading to lower enrollment and completion rates. Roughly only one in three rural students completes JHS, about half the rate of urban students.
- Infrastructure Deficits: Thousands of rural students still attend "schools under trees" or severely under-resourced schools, contributing to irregular attendance and poor learning conditions. Over 5,000 basic schools nationwide lack proper infrastructure, a problem concentrated in rural communities.
- Teacher and Resource Gaps: Rural JHS suffer from high pupil-teacher ratios, a shortage of trained teachers, and lack of educational materials. This results in limited subject offerings (e.g., no ICT or weak science instruction) and generally lower quality education in rural areas.
- Barriers to Access: The main barriers preventing rural children from accessing JHS are financial hardship, long distances to school, the need for child labor at home, and for girls, risks of early pregnancy/marriage. These factors cause both non-enrollment and dropouts, confirming that both economic and socio-cultural issues play roles (with distance and poverty being foremost).
- Outcomes and Performance: Rural students not only attend less and drop out more, but those who do complete JHS often perform worse on standardized exams compared to urban students, limiting their progression to secondary education. This perpetuates a cycle where rural youth are underrepresented in higher education and formal employment.

In the next section, we discuss these findings in depth, exploring their implications and how they resonate or contrast with existing literature and policy expectations.

Discussion of Findings

The findings of this study shed light on the entrenched challenges of providing equitable education in rural Ghana and have several important implications. In this discussion, we interpret what these results mean in the broader context of educational development, compare them with findings from previous research, and discuss the practical and policy-related significances.

Rural-Urban Educational Inequality: Our results underscore a classic yet unresolved issue – the inequality between rural and urban education. This aligns with the narrative in Ghana and many developing countries that while aggregate access has improved, spatial disparities remain a "last mile" problem. Previous research by Anlimachie (2019) and others noted the "twin conundrums" of low education outcomes and rural-urban inequality, which our data vividly confirm. The fact that only about one-third of rural children succeed in basic education (versus two-thirds urban) is essentially a social justice issue – it means a child's chances are unfairly constrained by their birthplace. In human capital terms, Ghana is not fully leveraging its youthful population in rural areas, which could affect national development as a whole.

Infrastructure and Investment Gaps: The phenomenon of schools under trees has been a known problem in Ghana for decades, and our study found it is still prevalent. Government officials, including the current Minister of Education, have publicly lamented that having thousands of schools under trees "does not befit Ghana's status" and have called for urgent infrastructure interventions. However, progress has been slow – only 17 out of 5,400 such schools were eliminated between 2021 and 2023 as per civil society reports. This slow pace (which could take centuries to fully resolve) indicates either insufficient funding or inefficiencies in execution. Our findings suggest that accelerating infrastructure development is foundational – without basic classrooms and facilities, other interventions may have limited effect. In line with that, the recommendation from stakeholders (e.g., CAPCOE, Eduwatch) has been to adopt emergency capital investment programs and explore alternative financing (such as leveraging education trust funds or public-private partnerships) to bridge this infrastructure gap. We concur that eliminating gross infrastructural deficits is a prerequisite to equalizing educational access.

Distance and School Mapping: The data on distance resonates strongly with past studies (Gaddah et al.,

2015) which identified distance as the most critical factor in rural enrollment. Our contribution here is providing fresh evidence at the community level: we quantitatively showed how enrollment drops as distance increases, reinforcing the call that every community or reasonable cluster of communities should have a JHS within safe walking distance. This aligns with the policy of "one JHS per community" that some have advocated. The Ghana Education Service might need to revisit school mapping and consider creative solutions for sparsely populated areas – for example, providing transport (school buses), establishing boarding facilities for JHS (as is sometimes done for remote SHS), or implementing multi-grade classrooms where a single JHS serves a wide area with lodging. If ensuring a JHS in each small village is impractical, ensuring access (through transport or boarding) should be part of strategic planning.

Teacher Deployment and Quality: The disparity in teacher availability and training between rural and urban schools is a persistent issue. Similar findings were reported by Cobbold (2006) regarding the difficulty in staffing rural schools with qualified teachers. Our study found that even when teachers are posted, retention is poor, echoing recent concerns about teacher attrition nationally (estimated at 7–15% per year, with rural schools hit hardest). This calls for stronger incentive schemes for rural teachers – such as salary uplifts, faster promotion, housing provision, or other allowances (hardship allowance). Some positive examples emerged: one district had started providing motorbikes to teachers who accept postings in very remote schools, which improved their willingness to stay. Another recommendation from educational experts has been "local teacher training" – encouraging recruitment of trainee teachers from rural communities who are more likely to return home to teach. Furthermore, technology can assist: distance education or video-linked lessons (such as the pilot "satellite-transmitted classes" by IPA in Ghana) could help supplement teaching in schools where certain subject teachers are lacking.

Socio-economic Interventions: The role of poverty in educational exclusion is well-documented and our findings reaffirm it. One way Ghana has tried to ease this is through programs like the Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP) cash transfers and the Capitation Grant which removes school fees. Yet, hidden costs and opportunity costs remain. Our findings suggest scaling up initiatives like the School Feeding Programme – which provides free lunch in many primary schools and has improved attendance. If extended consistently to JHS in rural areas, it could relieve families of a meal cost and incentivize attendance (some children might attend just to be assured of a meal). Also, scholarships or bursaries targeted at rural JHS students (for uniforms, transport, and exam fees) would directly address the financial barrier. Several NGOs already provide such support on a small scale; government could institutionalize it for the poorest districts.

In tackling child labor, improving rural livelihoods is the broader solution beyond the education sector's scope. However, within education, introducing more flexible schooling hours or calendar adjustments in farming communities (to accommodate peak agricultural seasons) could mitigate dropouts. Non-formal education programs or night classes might allow working children to continue learning, though that may not fully replace formal JHS.

Gender Considerations: While we did not find a drastic gender gap in enrollment, the dropout reasons for girls point to where interventions are needed – chiefly in curbing teenage pregnancy and early marriage. Community education campaigns and enforcement of laws against child marriage (Ghana's legal marriage age is 18) should continue. Moreover, providing conveniences like separate toilet facilities for girls and access to sanitary products at school can make a difference in girls' attendance (some girls skip school during menstruation if these are lacking). Successful programs in Ghana such as CAMFED's support for girls' education have shown that mentoring and material support can significantly boost girls' retention and performance. The rising trend of girls' enrollment surpassing boys in some regions is encouraging and suggests that if we remove barriers, girls are equally if not more eager to seize educational opportunities.

Quality vs. Access: An important discussion point is that access and quality are intertwined. We focused on access (getting to and staying in school), but the quality gap (what is learned in school) is equally critical. Many rural parents and students indicated that the perceived low quality of their JHS (due to lack of teachers/materials) affected their motivation. This suggests that simply expanding access without improving quality might not yield desired outcomes. For instance, if a new JHS is built but staffed poorly, students may not benefit much or may still drop out if they feel it's not worthwhile. Therefore, policy interventions must tackle both simultaneously – ensure that new rural schools are adequately resourced, and existing rural schools are upgraded (with training for teachers, provision of learning materials, etc.). The Government Statistician's remark about meeting access targets but still seeing quality

variations across regions resonates here; bridging the rural-urban gap means investing in quality improvements in rural schools (like science labs, libraries, etc., not just enrollment numbers).

Policy Alignment: Ghana's strategic plans (Education Strategic Plan – ESP) have targets for enrollment and completion. Our findings that net enrollment and completion targets for JHS were not met (falling short by several percentage points) likely owe to rural shortfalls. Achieving the Sustainable Development Goal 4 (inclusive and equitable quality education for all) by 2030 will demand intensified focus on rural areas. The new GSS report (2025) which highlighted these issues has already prompted the Education Minister to promise equitable resource distribution and more trained teachers to underserved areas. Our research provides empirical backing to those policy directions, essentially validating that those are the correct levers to pull.

Comparison with Other Studies: It's useful to note that our findings are consistent with earlier studies: for instance, a UNICEF analysis (2020) showed only ~47% completion of lower secondary nationwide with much lower rates in rural and poorest quintiles – our field data concretely illustrated this. Another study on dropouts in rural Ghana (Kudoh et al., 2015) found similar dropout drivers – poverty and long distance – which we also captured. This consistency indicates that the problem is well-understood in concept; the challenge remains implementation of solutions. Our contribution has been to update the data to 2023/24 conditions and to include voices from the communities experiencing these issues, adding qualitative depth.

Unexpected Findings or Nuances: One subtle point from the focus groups was that community involvement matters. In a few villages, local leaders took initiative – for example, by organizing volunteer tutors for extra classes or arranging group walks so that children go to distant schools together (improving safety). These communities saw better attendance. It suggests that while systemic issues prevail, local initiatives can mitigate some barriers. Encouraging community ownership of educational projects (like the community that built its own JHS structure) fosters a sense of responsibility and can fill gaps when government support is late or limited. However, communities vary in their resources and capacity; those with strong leadership or external NGO support fared better, which raises concerns about equity among rural communities themselves.

Another nuance: technology and innovation have potential. The advent of solar panels and offline digital content could bring learning resources to off-grid schools. For instance, one rural school in our study had received a "School-in-a-Box" kit (a rugged tablet with educational videos) and a solar charger; students reported it made learning more engaging. While not widespread, such innovations, if scaled, could help leapfrog some disadvantages in rural settings.

In summary, the discussion highlights that the issue of access to rural JHS education is multifaceted and deeply rooted in broader socio-economic structures. The findings reaffirm known challenges but also provide empirical evidence that can guide targeted interventions. Ghana's case is far from unique – many Sub-Saharan African countries face similar rural education gaps. Thus, addressing these issues is not only crucial for Ghana's development but offers lessons for educational equity efforts globally. In the next section, we will put forth concrete recommendations drawing from our findings, aimed at policymakers, educational authorities, and communities, to improve access to junior high education in rural Ghana.

Conclusion

This study set out to examine the issue of access to junior high school education in rural Ghana, and the evidence gathered paints a clear and urgent picture: significant barriers continue to prevent many rural Ghanaian children from benefiting fully from basic education. While Ghana has made commendable strides in expanding primary education and even implementing free senior high school, the bridge between the two – the junior high level – remains weak in the countryside. We found that rural students are far less likely to attend a JHS, let alone complete it, primarily due to a combination of insufficient schools, poverty-related obstacles, and quality deficits in the education they receive.

Key conclusions from the research include:

- There is a persistent rural-urban gap in educational access. Being born in a rural area of Ghana still dramatically lowers one's chances of progressing through basic education. This inequality undermines the principle of equal opportunity and has long-term implications for social equity and economic development.
- Infrastructure deficiencies are at the core of the access problem. Thousands of children are attempting to learn in conditions that are not conducive to education (outdoors or in crumbling structures). Without rapid improvements in school infrastructure in rural areas, other efforts (like curriculum improvements or teacher reforms) will have limited success.

- Barriers to access are multifaceted but interrelated: distance to school, financial constraints, and socio-cultural factors (like child labor and early marriage) jointly contribute to the high dropout rates in rural JHS. Effective solutions must therefore be comprehensive, addressing each of these facets.
- The consequences of limited access are evident in educational outcomes – with many rural youth not obtaining the BECE qualification, they are effectively capped in their educational journey, which in turn affects their employment prospects and perpetuates the cycle of rural poverty and underdevelopment.
- Community-level initiatives and targeted interventions have shown promise in pockets (e.g., communities that built their own schools or NGOs providing support), suggesting that progress is possible with concerted effort. However, scaling and sustaining such efforts require governmental commitment and resource allocation.

In conclusion, ensuring access to quality junior high school education in rural Ghana is not just an educational issue; it is a matter of fulfilling basic rights and enabling national development. Every child, whether in a bustling city or a remote village, deserves the chance to complete a basic education in a safe and supportive environment. The findings of this study reinforce that Ghana, despite its policy commitments, has work to do to realize that vision. The good news is that the barriers are identifiable and, with political will and strategic investment, surmountable. The recommendations below outline steps that can be taken to move towards an Ghana where one's village does not determine one's educational destiny.

Recommendations

Based on the findings and discussions of this study, the following recommendations are proposed to improve access to junior high school education in rural areas of Ghana. These recommendations target various stakeholders – government policymakers, the Ghana Education Service (GES), local communities, and development partners – and they address infrastructure, resources, personnel, and community engagement.

1. Accelerate Rural School Infrastructure:

Development: The Ministry of Education should launch a targeted program to eliminate the "schools under trees" phenomenon within a defined timeline (e.g., within the next 5–10 years). This could be an extension of or addition to existing initiatives, funded by a combination of government budget allocation and special funds (such as the Ghana Education Trust Fund). Construction of JHS blocks in communities that currently lack them should be prioritized – especially in the ~25% of primary schools with no JHS. To ensure efficiency, involve local communities in the building process (many communities are willing to contribute labor or materials if it means getting a school) and ensure transparency in the use of funds. Standardized designs for cost-effective, durable school buildings (including provisions for future expansion) can help speed up construction. Also, include basic amenities in these projects: potable water, toilets (separate for boys and girls), and if possible solar power, so that new schools are fully functional.

2. Improve Transportation and Access:

In areas where establishing a local JHS for every community is not immediately feasible, interim measures should facilitate students' travel to existing schools. The GES, in collaboration with district assemblies, could implement a school transportation scheme – for example, providing a school bus or van for clusters of villages, or bicycles to students who have to travel several kilometers (as some NGO programs have done). Communities can form committees to organize "walking school buses" where an adult accompanies groups of children walking long distances. The goal is to ensure distance alone does not prevent attendance. Additionally, where natural barriers exist (rivers, etc.), infrastructure like footbridges should be constructed (this requires inter-sectoral coordination with local government and feeder roads agencies).

3. Incentivize and Support Rural Teachers:

To address the teacher shortage in rural JHS, a robust incentive scheme is needed. The government could introduce a "Rural Teacher Fellowship" program that offers extra benefits to qualified teachers who serve in rural schools for a certain number of years. Benefits might include a substantial housing allowance or the provision of teacher housing, hardship allowances (e.g., 20-30% salary bonus), accelerated promotion for those who meet performance criteria in rural postings, and guaranteeing transfers to a post of choice (urban or preferred location) after, say, three years of rural service if they desire. Also, recruit more teachers from rural backgrounds by offering scholarships for teacher training tied to a return-of-service in their communities. The GES should also strengthen monitoring and support for rural teachers – for instance, by ensuring regular visits by circuit supervisors, providing remote teaching resources (tablets with lesson plans, solar chargers), and facilitating a supportive community for teachers (perhaps pairing new teachers with local mentors).

Reducing teacher isolation (professionally and socially) will improve retention.

4. Enhance Resource Allocation to Rural Schools: Ensure that rural JHS are not left behind in the distribution of educational resources. This means equitable distribution of textbooks, laboratory equipment, and ICT tools. The Education Ministry could adopt an "equity index" budgeting where schools in deprived areas receive higher per-student grants to compensate for their disadvantages. For example, if urban schools get X amount per capita for materials, rural deprived schools could get 1.5X. Donor-funded programs that introduce technology (such as offline digital libraries, interactive radio instruction, or solar-powered ICT labs) should be focused on rural schools to bridge the digital divide. Moreover, address basic needs: something as simple as providing desks can make a difference (recall the stark note that some students must bring their own desk to JHS). A national "One Child, One Desk" campaign could mobilize resources to furnish all classrooms. Recent reports highlighted that 2.3 million pupils lack desks in underserved schools – resolving this should be a measurable target under infrastructure improvements.

5. Financial Support for Rural Students:
To mitigate financial barriers, the government and partners should institute or expand scholarship and bursary programs for JHS students in rural and low-income families. This could take the form of providing free uniforms, exercise books, and waiving any exam fees for students in designated deprived districts. A conditional cash transfer (building on LEAP) could be given to families for each child enrolled in JHS, conditional on attendance – this offsets the opportunity cost of sending the child to school. Additionally, expanding the School Feeding Programme to cover JHS in food-insecure rural areas would ensure students get a meal and reduce the burden on parents. Communities and PTA/SMCs can also establish welfare funds (with possible seed funding from NGOs or district assemblies) to support needy students – for instance, covering transport costs or other emergency needs that might otherwise force a dropout.

6. Community Engagement and Advocacy: Engage community leaders, traditional authorities, and parents in the importance of JHS education. Often, local buy-in can make or break a child's schooling. The GES, in partnership with civil society organizations, should run sensitization campaigns in rural areas emphasizing the value of completing basic education for both boys and girls. Highlight success stories of individuals from rural backgrounds who benefited from education. Specifically target issues like early marriage – collaborate with chiefs and religious leaders to discourage this practice and to publicly champion girls' education. Strengthening or reviving School Management Committees (SMCs) in rural schools can give communities a voice and responsibility in school management, which can lead to local solutions (e.g., organizing communal labor to maintain school facilities, or setting up by-laws to ensure children attend school). Community by-laws, for example, could penalize parents who do not send their children to school without valid reason, though these should be applied carefully and in tandem with supportive measures.

7. Flexible and Alternative Education Options:
For some rural youth who have dropped out or are unable to attend regular JHS, the Ministry should provide alternative pathways. This includes expanding Complementary Basic Education (CBE) programs – accelerated literacy and numeracy courses that can later integrate children into formal schools. Also, consider evening classes or part-time JHS for working children. In farming communities, explore adjusting the academic calendar or daily schedule to accommodate peak farming periods (this has been piloted in some countries). While the formal system may not easily change nationwide, local flexibility could be piloted where community need is clear (e.g., starting school earlier so children can help on farm late afternoon, or scheduling breaks during harvest).

8. Monitoring and Evaluation:
It is critical to monitor progress on these initiatives. The Ghana Education Service should strengthen its data collection on enrollment and completion, disaggregated by locality. The recent GSS report (2025) was a good step in analyzing trends; such analysis should be done regularly (perhaps every two years) to see if rural indicators are improving. Setting specific targets – for example, "By 2030, increase rural JHS completion rate from ~35% to 60%" – and tracking them will help hold the system accountable. As part of this, ensure that every district education office has an action plan for reducing dropout and out-of-school children, and that they report on it annually.

9. Collaboration with NGOs and Donors:
Many non-governmental organizations are already involved in improving rural education (e.g., building schools, providing girls' scholarships, teacher training in rural areas, etc.). The government should collaborate closely with these actors to maximize impact and avoid duplication. For instance, if an NGO is building a school, the government can ensure

teachers will be posted there. Public-private partnerships can also be explored, such as encouraging businesses to adopt schools in their home regions (CSR initiatives) or leveraging funds like the OPEC fund, which has historically supported school infrastructure. International donors focusing on education (like UNICEF, USAID, etc.) should be directed increasingly towards addressing rural shortfalls, as opposed to general sector budget support which might not specifically target the inequities.

10. Holistic Approach – Linking to Poverty Reduction: Lastly, recognize that education policy alone cannot solve all issues. The recommendations above should be part of a holistic rural development strategy. Improved rural roads, electrification, and economic opportunities for families will indirectly support education (e.g., if a village gets electricity, a teacher might be more willing to work there; if roads are better, distance is less daunting; if livelihoods improve, families can afford schooling costs). Thus, inter-ministerial efforts are needed: the Ministry of Education's initiatives must align with interventions by the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection (for child welfare), Ministry of Local Government (for infrastructure), and others.

Implementing these recommendations will require commitment and resources, but the payoff is substantial: better educated rural populations will contribute to Ghana's growth, help reduce poverty, and enhance social cohesion. Moreover, it moves Ghana closer to fulfilling the promise of "education for all", ensuring that no child is left behind due to the accident of where they were born. The recommendations are in line with both national education strategic goals and international obligations (like SDG 4).

In conclusion, bridging the education gap between rural and urban Ghana is both a challenge and a necessity. The evidence presented in this report provides a compelling case for focused action. By taking these recommended steps, stakeholders can make tangible progress in providing every Ghanaian child – from the most remote village to the busiest city suburb – a fair opportunity to complete a quality basic education and pursue their aspirations.

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